

BJP LEADERS REFUTE THE CHARGE THAT THE **'BHARAT NARRATIVE' IS POLITICALLY MOTIVATED AND ARGUE THAT 'INDIA' IS A RELIC** FROM THE NATION'S COLONIAL PAST

tile stand against the Bharat commentary but is also unwilling to let go of the advantage of their INDIA acronym. Saying that both names are mentioned in the Constitution and are perfectly acceptable, Rahul described the India vs Bharat debate as "distraction tactics" and a sign of the BJP's "fear" ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. Other leaders such as West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee and her Delhi counterpart Arvind Kejriwal, too, have called the 'Bharat narrative' politically motivated.

BJP leaders refute the allegation and argue that 'India' is a relic from the nation's colonial past. If Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami hails the turn to Bharat as "another blow to the slavery mentality", Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan calls it the biggest blow to the "colonial mindset".

Bharat and India have often also been used to denote the two Indias—one un-anglicised, poor and living in the villages and the other an upwardly mobile urban population. With 65 per cent population living in the villages, this India vs Bharat discourse is certainly aimed at adding another front to the BJP's nationalistic discourse. "When you say Bharat, it evokes a sense, a meaning and a connotation," external affairs minister S. Jaishankar said in an interview.

The BJP is hoping the debate will dilute the advantage the Opposition parties seek to gain with INDIA in 2024. The proponents of Bharat, a Sanskrit word that finds mention in Hindu mythological texts, lost no time in labelling the INDIA block anti-Hindu when two leaders of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), including party chief and Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin's son Udayanidhi, made unsavoury comments on *Sanatana dharma* (an alternative name for Hinduism). "INDIA has been formed to attack Hinduism," former Union minister and senior BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad remarked. What also makes things difficult for the INDIA block is that some of its members have earlier demanded the name change to Bharat. In 2012, former Congress MP from Goa Shantaram Naik had moved a bill in the Rajya Sabha to make changes to that effect. In 2004, Samajwadi Party chief and then Uttar Pradesh CM, the late Mulayam Singh Yadav, had passed a resolution in the assembly to replace the phrase 'India that is Bharat' with 'Bharat that is India'.

However, the Bharat move may not happen right now, according to BJP insiders. On September 11, when the Union government hosted Saudi Arabia's crown prince Mohammed bin Salman, the communique went back to 'Republic of India'. That said, legal experts say the name change can be executed through a constitutional amendment, but it would require it to be passed by a two-thirds majority in both houses of Parliament and ratification by at least half of the states.

While the spin doctors on both sides are raising the roof on the debate, for the last half a century, both India and Bharat have been used interchangeably by the governments of the day sans any conflict. Which is possibly why the Supreme Court rejected two appeals—by individual petitioners in 2016 and 2020—seeking a name change for the country. The current confrontation, therefore, is most likely a storm in a teacup, perhaps with an electoral motive. ■